



Starting points - Representation

Consider how representations are constructed through a process of selection and combination.

Newspapers have access to the same stories daily, but will choose how to represent events and issues, reflecting the **values, attitudes and beliefs** of the paper and their readers. The stories that make it on to the **news agenda** of a particular newspaper will be determined by a range of factors including the readership and the ideology of the newspaper. The *Daily Mirror* will usually represent the Labour government and their policies positively and will be critical of the Conservative and Reform Party as they do not share their political viewpoint. The way in which the event/issue/social group is represented will affect the audience response. Newspapers are **opinion leaders** and may influence how audiences respond to an issue/event.

Consider how issues, events and social groups are represented across the set newspaper pages from the *Daily Mirror*:

The front page

- The construction of the representation of the main story and the choices made by the newspaper regarding how to re-present and mediate this story for its readers, will construct a specific representation. The main story is constructed through the choice of headline, caption and image. The selection and combination of images and text convey the attitude and belief of the newspaper whose political allegiance is left-wing and pre-Brexit, was generally pro-Europe. The use of positive, emotive language 'WIN-WIN' and the visual codes of Keir Starmer's smile and thumbs up gesture construct a positive representation of the event reflecting the viewpoint of the newspaper.
- To illustrate how the same story may be represented differently by different newspapers, it may be useful to look at other publications for the same day. For example, the *Daily Mail*, a politically right-leaning newspaper, ran the headline '*Starmer's Surrender*' with the strapline, '*Day the Brexit Dream Died*'.
- The response of the readers to the representation of the event would be to accept the newspaper's view as it reinforces their own ideas about the government. The way in which the story is represented also reflects the changing position of the readership regarding Brexit.
- The inclusion of 'shoppers, tourists and businesses' as beneficiaries of the deal in the story reinforces the newspaper's concerns for the ordinary person and what they consider as important.
- The representation of celebrities on the front page is sympathetic. The choice of the image of Gary Lineker, who is usually presented positively by the newspaper as many of the readers will be fans of *Match of The Day*, is positive, reflecting the idea that he is 'contrite'. Similarly, the representation of the other celebrities featured, along with the King, suggests they have interests in common with the ordinary readers of the newspaper, such as gardening. Amy Dowden and Kate Garraway are smiling and engaging in direct mode of address with the reader.